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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 2 — The Funding Landscape

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 2. Use it during and after the video to reinforce what you learned, apply the concepts to your own organization, and build toward a real grant proposal. Work through each section in order.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

Review these terms before moving on. They come up throughout the module and will anchor your understanding of the funding landscape.

Grant Proposal	A formal written request submitted to a funder asking for financial support for a specific program, project, or operational need.
Funder / Grantor	The organization or entity providing the grant funds — could be a federal agency, state program, private foundation, or corporation.
Mission Alignment	The degree to which your organization's goals and the funder's priorities overlap. Strong alignment is essential for competitive proposals.
RFP	Request for Proposal — a formal document released by a funder that outlines a specific grant opportunity, eligibility requirements, and application guidelines.
Program Officer	The funder's staff member who manages a grant program, reviews proposals, and serves as your primary contact at a foundation or agency.

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Clarity	One of three things grant reviewers look for: can they easily understand what you are proposing?
Feasibility	One of three things grant reviewers look for: is your plan realistic and achievable within your capacity and timeline?
Impact	One of three things grant reviewers look for: will your project make a meaningful, measurable difference?
Track Record	Your organization's documented history of managing grants responsibly, delivering on commitments, and reporting accurately.
Boilerplate	Reusable sections of proposal language (organization description, mission statement, etc.) that are customized for each funder before submission.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated proposal excerpt below. The callouts on the right explain what each element is doing and why it works. As you read, think about how you would write a similar section for your own organization.

Sample: Mission Alignment Statement

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
<i>Citywide Youth Mentorship (CYM) respectfully requests \$75,000 to expand our after-school academic coaching program to two additional school sites in the Riverside Unified School District.</i> <i>This request directly supports the Horizon Foundation's 2025 priority to increase academic achievement among underserved students in Inland Southern California.</i>	→ Specific dollar amount → Named program with a clear purpose → Geographic specificity builds credibility → Explicitly echoes the funder's stated priority — this is mission alignment in action
<i>CYM has served 1,200+ youth annually for 14 years. Last year, 89% of participants improved their GPA by at least one full grade point. We have managed seven foundation grants totaling \$1.2M</i>	→ Concrete numbers, not vague claims → Outcome data (89% / GPA) demonstrates impact

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with no audit findings.

→ Track record statement builds trust and shows competency

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what a competitive proposal says instead. After each pair, write what specifically changed and why it matters.

Comparison 1 — Mission Alignment

☐ Weak

Our organization works with youth in the community and believes in the power of education to change lives. We are applying for this grant because our programs help students succeed.

☐ Strong

Riverside Youth Connect serves 850 low-income students aged 11–18 across four Title I schools in Riverside County. This request supports your foundation's stated commitment to closing the academic achievement gap in underserved communities — the precise population and outcome our program targets.

☐ What changed between the weak and strong version? What made it stronger?

Comparison 2 — Urgency & Community Need

☐ Weak

There is a big need for mental health services in our community. Many people are struggling and do not have access to the help they need. Our program addresses this need.

☐ Strong

In [Your County], 1 in 3 adults experiencing a mental health crisis has no access to outpatient care within 30 days. Our mobile crisis response team reduced emergency room visits among program participants by 41% last year — proof that immediate, community-based intervention works.

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- What specific techniques did the strong version use to establish urgency?

Comparison 3 — Track Record & Accountability

□ Weak

We have been doing this work for many years and have helped a lot of people. Our team is passionate and dedicated to our mission.

□ Strong

Founded in 2008, our organization has administered 12 federal and foundation grants totaling \$3.4M with zero audit findings. In our most recent program year, we served 1,640 individuals, exceeded all contractual outcome targets, and submitted every funder report on time.

- How does the strong version build funder confidence? What would you add about your own organization?

Section 4 — Your Organization's Grant Readiness Profile

Complete each prompt as thoroughly as you can. This is not a final proposal — it is the raw material you will draw from when you write one. Be specific. Avoid vague language. Every blank you fill in here is a sentence you won't have to struggle with later.

Part A — Your Organization at a Glance

- Organization name and year founded:

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- ☐ Your mission statement (write it exactly as it appears in your official documents):

- ☐ Who do you serve? (Be specific: age range, geography, population characteristics)

- ☐ How many people did you serve in the most recently completed program year?

☐ **Tip:** If you don't know the exact number, check your most recent program report or annual data summary. Funders will ask.

Part B — Your Program or Project

- ☐ Name of the program or project you want to seek funding for:

- ☐ What problem does this program address? Use data if you have it.

- ☐ What does your program do? (Describe activities, timeline, and who is involved.)

- ☐ What does success look like? Write at least one specific, measurable outcome.

★**Example — Measurable outcome:**

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By June 30, 2026, 80% of program participants will demonstrate a 20% or greater improvement in [target skill/behavior] as measured by [assessment tool].

Part C — Your Track Record

- ☐ List up to three grants your organization has received (funder, amount, year):

- ☐ What is the strongest evidence that your programs work? (Data, evaluations, outcomes)

☐ **Tip:** If you're a newer organization without a grant history, describe any contracts, fee-for-service agreements, or community partnerships that demonstrate your capacity to manage funds and deliver results.

Part D — Your Funding Landscape

- ☐ List two to three types of funders most likely to support your mission (federal, state, corporate, foundation, etc.) and why:

- ☐ Name one specific funder you are interested in pursuing. What do you know about their priorities?

- ☐ Does this funder's mission align with yours? Where exactly is the overlap?

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Section 5 — Module 2 Self-Audit Checklist

Use this checklist to assess where you stand right now. Check each box you can honestly say is true for your organization. Unchecked boxes are your action items before Module 3.

The Funding Landscape

- ☐ I can name at least three distinct types of funding sources relevant to my mission (e.g., federal grants, private foundations, corporate giving).
- ☐ I understand that each funding source has its own culture, rules, and expectations — and I do not apply the same approach to all of them.
- ☐ I know where to research funders in my issue area (foundation directories, federal grants databases, state agency websites).

Strategic Alignment

- ☐ Before pursuing any grant, I ask: does this funding opportunity genuinely match my organization's mission and program?
- ☐ I have walked away (or am willing to walk away) from a grant opportunity that was not a good fit.
- ☐ I can articulate in two sentences what my organization does, who it serves, and what outcomes it produces.

Proposal Readiness

- ☐ My grant requests are always for a specific dollar amount with a clear and justifiable use of funds.
- ☐ I have current outcome data I can include in a proposal narrative (not just activity counts — actual results).
- ☐ My proposal narrative tells a story that connects my program to real, measurable outcomes the funder cares about.

The Five Elements

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- ❑ **ALIGNMENT:** My proposals connect directly and explicitly to the funder's stated mission and priorities.
- ❑ **COMMUNITY BENEFIT:** I can specifically answer who benefits, how many benefit, and how their lives will be different.
- ❑ **URGENCY:** I use current data and community evidence to demonstrate that the problem is pressing and real.
- ❑ **COMPETENCY:** I can demonstrate through track record and staff qualifications that my organization can deliver.
- ❑ **ACCOUNTABILITY:** My proposals describe how funds will be tracked, outcomes measured, and results reported.

Organizational Compliance

- ❑ My organization is properly registered and in good standing with the appropriate state authority in my state.
- ❑ My IRS determination letter (501(c)(3) status confirmation) is current, accessible, and on file.
- ❑ My most recent audited financials are complete and available to attach to a proposal.

My unchecked items — what I need to address before my next submission:

*"The proposals that get funded are not written by the luckiest organizations.
They are written by the most prepared ones."*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 2